

The Wall Street Dream Market

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“W_{all Street},” reads the sinister old gag, “is a street with a river at one end and a graveyard at the other.”

This is pretty neat, but, if only there were a kindergarten located in the middle, it would be even neater.

For over ten years I have been viewing the activities of this street each working day, mostly from the vantage point of a trading desk. We have access, in this business, to every form of communication except the heliograph. What we are constantly exchanging over an incredible network of wires are quotations, orders, bluffs, fibs, lies, and nonsense. The first four are the necessary agenda of doing brokerage in securities. The downright lies are rather exceptional and in the long run prove to be unprofitable business practice. What I am interested in examining here is the nonsense—a commodity which keeps sluicing in through the weeks and years with the irresistible constancy of the waters of the rolling Mississippi.

Over these many wires it is my job to talk constantly with order clerks, traders, partners, and speculators. The first part of their conversation is usually sensible and competent and sometimes verges on the brilliant. This is the part